

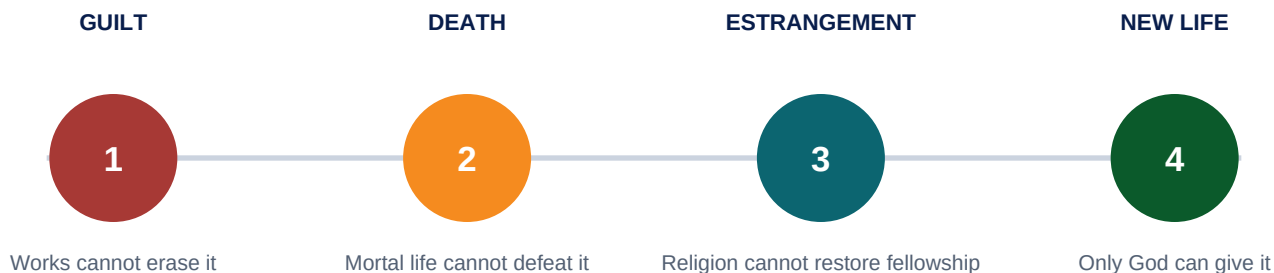
WHY CAN'T WE SAVE OURSELVES?

Why Effort, Religion, and Good Intentions Cannot Bring Us Home

BIG IDEA: Human effort cannot erase guilt, overthrow death, restore fellowship, or create the life that only God can give.

ACTIVITY 1 - FOLLOW THE STORY

Number the four movements in order. Then tell a partner what changes from the first movement to the last.



ACTIVITY 2 - KEY WORDS

Choose three words from the box. Write one sentence explaining how they belong to this lesson.

GRACE

WORKS

GUILT

DEATH

LIFE

FAITH

MEMORY VERSE - EPHESIANS 2:8-9

"For by grace are ye saved through faith... Not of works, lest any man should boast."

WHY CAN'T WE SAVE OURSELVES?

Match, compare, and respond

ACTIVITY 3 - MATCH THE TRUTH

Draw a line from each lesson word on the left to its meaning on the right.

1. GUILT

C. Religion cannot declare peace with God

2. DEATH

D. No person can cause his own birth

3. FELLOWSHIP

A. Later good deeds cannot make rebellion untrue

4. NEW BIRTH

B. Mortal life cannot create resurrection life

ACTIVITY 4 - BEFORE AND AFTER

MY EFFORT

>

GOD'S GRACE

ACHIEVED

>

RECEIVED

ROOT

>

FRUIT

THINK AND WRITE

The religious achievement I might trust is:

Good works belong after salvation as:

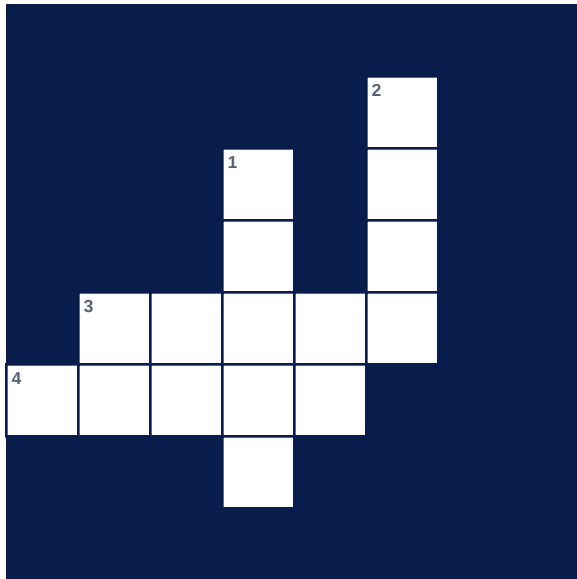
BOTTOM LINE: Salvation is not self-improvement. God must do what the lost cannot do.

WHY CAN'T WE SAVE OURSELVES?

A family activity for this week's lesson

CROSSWORD - WHAT GRACE MUST DO

Complete the four crossing lesson words. Each answer names something human effort cannot produce or the way salvation is received.



CROSSWORD CLUES

1 DOWN - The power mortal life cannot overthrow.

2 DOWN - What only God can give in Christ.

3 ACROSS - God acting for those who cannot rescue themselves.

4 ACROSS - Receives Christ; it does not earn salvation.

TALK ABOUT IT AT HOME

1. What does Ephesians 2:1-10 show about this week's truth?
2. That effort cannot solve guilt because:
3. How does this lesson lead us toward Jesus Christ?

THIS WEEK: When you treat salvation like a project, name the task you cannot complete and ask what grace means there.

PRAY: Lord, show us Your truth and lead us to trust and follow Jesus Christ.

WHY CAN'T WE SAVE OURSELVES?

A personal reflection for this week's lesson

CENTRAL TRUTH: Human effort cannot erase guilt, overthrow death, restore fellowship, or create the life that only God can give.

1 - TRACE THE MOVEMENT

MY EFFORT

>

GOD'S GRACE

ACHIEVED

>

RECEIVED

ROOT

>

FRUIT

2 - PERSONAL AUDIT

The religious achievement I might trust is:

That effort cannot solve guilt because:

Good works belong after salvation as:

Receiving grace instead of boasting means:

3 - TEST THE CLAIM

A student says, "God will accept me because I am trying harder than most people." Which impossible tasks can effort never accomplish?

SEVEN-DAY CHALLENGE: When you treat salvation like a project, name the task you cannot complete and ask what grace means there.

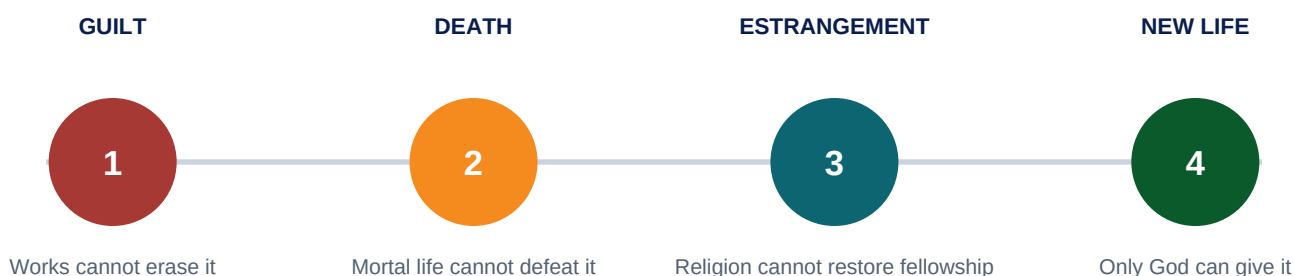
Questions are welcome. Ask a trusted leader to open Scripture with you privately.

WHY CAN'T WE SAVE OURSELVES?

Answers, family conversation, and pastoral safeguards

JUNIOR WORKSHEET ANSWERS

Activity 1: Use the numbered path below. Invite students to explain each movement in their own words.



Activity 3 matching answers

1. GUILT: Later good deeds cannot make rebellion untrue
2. DEATH: Mortal life cannot create resurrection life
3. FELLOWSHIP: Religion cannot declare peace with God
4. NEW BIRTH: No person can cause his own birth

TAKE-HOME CROSSWORD ANSWERS



1 Down: DEATH. 2 Down: LIFE. 3 Across: GRACE. 4 Across: FAITH.
Reinforce the order: grace is God's saving action; faith receives Christ; new life follows in Him.

WHY CAN'T WE SAVE OURSELVES?

Helping young people respond honestly to the Gospel

THEOLOGICAL AIM

Human effort cannot erase guilt, overthrow death, restore fellowship, or create the life that only God can give.

DISCUSSION GUIDANCE

Let students answer without forcing disclosure. Keep the lesson's controlling movement clear, return unclear answers to Ephesians 2:1-10; Romans 3:19-28, and keep Jesus Christ Himself at the center rather than treating salvation as detached benefits.

FAMILY CONVERSATION

1. The religious achievement I might trust is:
2. That effort cannot solve guilt because:
3. What does this lesson reveal about Jesus Christ?
4. What honest next step would faithfulness require?

PASTORAL SAFEGUARDS

- Do not force a profession or make public disclosure the price of help.
- Do not reassure automatically from a prayer, baptism, attendance, emotion, or puzzle answer.
- Distinguish conviction, questions, resistance, doubt, and present trust before responding.
- Keep union with Christ central: salvation is not a collection of benefits apart from Him.
- Remember the settled order: the sinner believes; the Spirit gives life.

PRIVATE INVITATION

You do not have to answer publicly or pretend certainty. Speak privately with one of us; we will listen and open the Bible with you.

WHY CAN'T WE SAVE OURSELVES?

Why Effort, Religion, and Good Intentions Cannot Bring Us Home

WE CANNOT ERASE GUILT

Good deeds cannot rewrite rebellion.

ROMANS 3:19-20



WE CANNOT OVERTHROW DEATH

Moral effort cannot produce resurrection life.

EPHESIANS 2:1, 6



RELIGION CANNOT RESTORE FELLOWSHIP

Christian proximity is not union with Christ.

TITUS 3:3-7



WE CANNOT CREATE LIFE

No person can cause his own new birth.

EPHESIANS 2:4-6



GRACE

God acts for those who cannot rescue themselves.

EPH. 2:8-9

GOD ANSWERS GUILT IN CHRIST

Grace accomplishes what works cannot.

ROMANS 3:24-26



CHRIST GIVES RESURRECTION LIFE

The risen Son brings life out of death.

1 CORINTHIANS 15:20-22



CHRIST BRINGS US TO GOD

He crosses the separation we cannot bridge.

1 PETER 3:18



THE SPIRIT GIVES LIFE IN CHRIST

New life is received; it is never manufactured.

EPHESIANS 2:4-6



THE WRONG TOOLS FOR AN IMPOSSIBLE TASK



EFFORT



RELIGION



GOOD INTENTIONS



MORAL IMPROVEMENT



ROOT BEFORE FRUIT



DEAD IN SIN



GOD GIVES LIFE



GOOD WORKS FOLLOW

SALVATION IS NOT SELF-IMPROVEMENT. GOD MUST DO WHAT THE LOST CANNOT DO.

If salvation depends on what only God can do, it must be received - not achieved.

EPHESIANS 2:8-10 | TITUS 3:3-7 | ROMANS 3:19-28